Social Media Research Paper

APA Research Paper · Unit 2 — Word Processing · Variation Project · 100 points · 31 tasks

How to use this instruction sheet. Download the starter file from the Project Grader, open it in Microsoft Word 365, and keep this sheet open beside it. Work through each task in order. Each task tells you what to do, why it matters, and where to find the tool — but you figure out the exact steps yourself. That's the learning. When you're done, save the file and upload it to the Variation 1 grader for instant scoring.

D1 — Manage Documents

19 points · 7 tasks

Task 1 — Set 1-inch margins on all sides (APA)

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA style requires 1-inch margins on all sides. Consistent margins are the foundation of a properly formatted research paper.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Layout tab → Page Setup group → Margins → Normal (1" all sides).

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The ruler shows 1-inch margins; white space is even on all four sides.

Task 2 — Set page orientation to Portrait

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Portrait is the standard orientation for academic papers.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Layout tab → Page Setup group → Orientation → Portrait.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Pages are taller than they are wide (8.5" × 11").

Task 3 — Apply the “Basic (Simple)” style set

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

A clean, simple style set keeps an academic paper readable and unfussy, letting the content stand out.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Design tab → Document Formatting group → Style Sets gallery → Basic (Simple).

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Headings adopt the Basic (Simple) look; the name appears on hover.

Task 4 — Insert a running head: title on the left, page number on the right

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA papers use a running head so the shortened title and page number appear on every page.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Header & Footer → Header → Edit Header. Type the short title at the left, Tab to the right, then insert a page number.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Every page shows the short title on the left and the page number on the right of the header.

Task 5 — Insert page numbers in the top-right of the header

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA places page numbers in the top-right corner of every page.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Header & Footer tab → Page Number → Top of Page → Plain Number 3.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Each page shows its number in the top-right corner.

Task 6 — Set document properties: Title, Author, Subject

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Document properties embed identifying metadata used by libraries, search, and submission systems.

WHERE TO FIND IT

File tab → Info → Properties panel. Fill in Title, Author, and Subject.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

File → Info shows the Title, Author, and Subject populated.

Task 7 — Use Find & Replace to change every “SM” to “social media”

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Spelling out abbreviations on first use (and throughout, in this case) is good academic practice. Find & Replace does it instantly.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Home tab → Editing → Replace (Ctrl+H). Find “SM”, Replace with “social media”, Replace All.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A message reports the replacements; searching for “SM” finds none afterward.

D2 — Format Text & Paragraphs

22 points · 7 tasks

Task 8 — Apply the Title style to the paper's title

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

The Title style formats the main heading and can be referenced by the Table of Contents.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the title → Home tab → Styles group → Title.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The title becomes large and distinct from the body text.

Task 9 — Apply Heading 1 to all major sections (at least 5)

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Heading 1 marks the major sections (Introduction, Methods, Results, etc.) and drives the automatic Table of Contents.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click each major section heading → Home tab → Styles group → Heading 1.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

At least five major sections use Heading 1 and appear as top-level items in the Navigation Pane.

Task 10 — Apply Heading 2 to all subsections

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Heading 2 marks subsections, appearing indented under their parent section in the Table of Contents.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click each subsection heading → Home tab → Styles group → Heading 2.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Subsections use Heading 2 and are indented in the Navigation Pane.

Task 11 — Set line spacing to double (2.0)

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA requires the entire paper to be double-spaced.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select all text (Ctrl+A) → Home tab → Line and Paragraph Spacing → 2.0.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

All text is double-spaced; the Paragraph dialog shows 2.0.

Task 12 — Set a first-line indent of 0.5 inches

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA paragraphs begin with a half-inch first-line indent.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select the body text → Home tab → Paragraph dialog launcher → Indentation → Special → First line → 0.5".

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Each paragraph's first line is indented half an inch; the ruler's first-line marker sits at 0.5".

Task 13 — Apply the Intense Quote character style to a key quotation

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

The Intense Quote style visually sets off an important quotation from the surrounding text.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select the quotation → Home tab → Styles group → Intense Quote.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The quotation appears in the distinct Intense Quote formatting.

Task 14 — Insert a page break before the References section

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

APA requires the References list to begin on its own new page.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click just before the References heading → press Ctrl+Enter (or Layout → Breaks → Page).

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The References section starts at the top of a new page.

D3 — Tables & Lists

16 points · 6 tasks

Task 15 — Create a 4-column survey data table

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Tables present survey data clearly in rows and columns.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Tables group → Table → select a 4-column grid.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A 4-column table appears; you can type in any cell.

Task 16 — Merge the header row cells

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Merging the header row lets you place a single spanning title across the table.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Select the top row → Table Layout tab → Merge group → Merge Cells.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Row 1 becomes one wide cell.

Task 17 — Sort the data table by response percentage

3 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Sorting by percentage orders the responses from most to least common, making patterns visible.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click in the table → Table Layout tab → Data group → Sort → choose the percentage column → Number → order.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Rows are ordered by the response-percentage column.

Task 18 — Create a numbered list of research questions

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

A numbered list presents the research questions in clear order.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Type each question on its own line, select them → Home tab → Numbering.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The research questions are numbered in sequence.

Task 19 — Create a bulleted list of key findings

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

A bulleted list presents the findings as distinct points.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Type each finding on its own line, select them → Home tab → Bullets.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Each key finding has a bullet.

Task 20 — Restart list numbering for the second numbered set

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

When a second numbered list should start at 1 (not continue the previous list), you restart its numbering.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Right-click the first item of the second list → Restart at 1.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The second list begins at 1 rather than continuing from the first list.

D4 — References

12 points · 3 tasks

Task 21 — Insert an automatic Table of Contents

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

An automatic TOC builds a clickable, page-numbered map of the paper from your heading styles.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Place the cursor on a blank page after the title → References tab → Table of Contents → an Automatic style.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A Table of Contents lists your headings with page numbers.

Task 22 — Customize the TOC to show Heading 1 and Heading 2 only

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Limiting the TOC to two levels keeps it concise for a research paper.

WHERE TO FIND IT

References tab → Table of Contents → Custom Table of Contents → Show levels: 2 → OK.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The TOC shows only Heading 1 and Heading 2 entries.

Task 23 — Insert 5 footnotes throughout the paper

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Footnotes provide citations and clarifying notes without interrupting the main text.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click where each note belongs → References tab → Insert Footnote → type the note. Do this five times.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Five superscript markers appear in the text with matching footnotes at the bottoms of their pages.

D5 — Graphic Elements

21 points · 5 tasks

Task 24 — Insert a bar-chart screenshot as a figure

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Figures visualize data. APA papers include charts as labeled figures.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Illustrations group → Pictures → This Device → select the chart image.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

The bar-chart image appears in the document.

Task 25 — Set the figure's text wrapping to Top and Bottom

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

Top-and-bottom wrapping keeps the figure on its own line with text above and below, as expected for academic figures.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Click the image → Picture Format tab → Arrange group → Wrap Text → Top and Bottom.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

Text sits above and below the figure rather than beside it.

Task 26 — Add text to a shape to create a callout box

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS

A callout box highlights a key statistic or takeaway.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Insert tab → Illustrations → Shapes → a callout/rectangle → draw it → type the statistic inside.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED

A shape containing your callout text appears in the document.

Task 27 — Position the callout shape in the right margin

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS
Placing the callout in the margin draws the eye without disrupting the body text.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Click the shape → Picture/Shape Format tab → Arrange group → Position → a right-side option (or drag it into the right margin).

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED
The callout shape sits in the right margin area.

Task 28 — Add descriptive alt text to all figures

7 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS
Alt text describes figures to screen-reader users and is required for accessibility compliance.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Right-click each figure/shape → Edit Alt Text → type a clear description.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED
Each figure shows your description in the Alt Text pane.

D6 — Collaboration

10 points · 3 tasks

Task 29 — Add a comment asking the professor for feedback

2 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS
Comments let you pose a question to a reviewer without altering the text.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Select the thesis or relevant text → Review tab → New Comment → type your question.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED
A comment bubble appears connected to the selected text.

Task 30 — Reply to the comment from your writing partner

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS
Replying creates a threaded discussion on the document.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Click your writing partner's existing comment → Reply → type your response.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED
Your reply appears indented under the original comment.

Task 31 — Turn on Track Changes and revise the methodology section

4 pt

WHY THIS MATTERS
Track Changes records each edit so a reviewer can accept or reject it.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Review tab → Tracking group → Track Changes (toggle on) → revise the methodology text.

HOW YOU'LL KNOW IT WORKED
Edits appear in a different color with underline/strikethrough markup.

Total: 100 points · 31 tasks. Every task on this sheet is graded automatically when you upload your file. © Dr. Mark Taormino